PHOTO: ANDI WOLFE

Featuring more than 1,000 pieces, today's Instant Gallery is the largest display of turned-wood objects under one roof

PHOTO: AMERICAN WOODTURNER

Turner Jerry Fant answers questions during an early symposium demonstration on hollow vessels

The concept of a service organisation did not gel until October 1985 during the Woodturning Vision and Concepts conference held at the Arrowmont School of Arts and Crafts in [Gatlinburg,] Tennessee. On the second day of the weekend event, 13 interested people gathered on the porch of the student dormitory, discussed the idea, and agreed to form the American Association of Woodturners (Kelsey, p. 55). It was clear that in order to become effective, this new organisation would need to be not-for-profit, be membership-based and have a basic philosophy that focused on education (Kelsey, p. 60).

The first AAW Board of Directors was formed by write-in votes from approximately 100 of the 250 delegates who attended the 1985 Arrowmont conference. Individuals receiving the highest number of votes would be elected president vice president, secretary, and treasurer. The remaining five would be known as board members at large (Kelsey, p. 58). No one on the original Board of Directors had the slightest idea of what they were getting into. They were not corporate types. They were unpaid. They had no previous experience or training (Kelsey, p. 58). What they did have was a love for woodturning and a desire to see woodturning not only continue but grow (Kelsey, p. 58). In any organisation, it is inevitable that board members will bring their own agenda, personal quirks, and biases to the meetings. But the overriding factors which influenced the AAW board's decisions were always:
1) what was best for the field of woodturning,
2) what was best for AAW members, and
3) how the board could improve growth, fellowship, and communications among AAW members.

David Ellsworth was elected the first AAW president and led the organisation through its formative years from 1986 to 1990. Reflecting on the experience Ellsworth revealed, 'It was expected that the beginning of any organisation would be filled with a number of rocks and rolls and, as expected the first years were an event-full experience. As president, I received the first rock when [our administrator] informed me that the printer he was using in Texas had mixed up the pages imprinting our first newsletter'

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